

Day 2 — Managing Engagement for Product Outcomes

Activity packet for participant triads. Today's job: design a **per-stakeholder engagement plan** — cadence, format, what they need, what we need — and draft SEP §2.

Where we are in the week

The map exists (Day 1). Today turns the map into a **plan**. Each stakeholder gets a deliberate engagement style: how often you talk, in what format, what each side gives and gets.

By 16:00, every triad has SEP §2 — the engagement plan that will guide the next quarter of stakeholder interactions.

Inputs

- SEP §1 (stakeholder map + RACI + watch list)
- TCD §6 (sign-off matrix with statuses)
- Whatever upcoming meetings or decisions are on the calendar

The four engagement principles

PRINCIPLE	PLAIN ENGLISH
Engage early	Surprise = anger. Surface concerns before they become decisions.
Engage deliberately	One channel per stakeholder. Avoid Slack-DM-plus-email-plus-meeting redundancy.
Match form to power	High-power stakeholders get crisp written updates; high-interest stakeholders get conversation.
Bidirectional asks	Every engagement names what <i>they</i> need from <i>us</i> AND what <i>we</i> need from <i>them</i> .

Most TPMs do (1) and (2) well by quarter 2 of the role. (3) and (4) are the differentiators.

Engagement style by quadrant

From yesterday's Power × Interest grid, today's engagement style:

QUADRANT	CADENCE	FORMAT	LENGTH
High Power + High Interest	Weekly or bi-weekly	Written brief + 30-min sync	Brief: 1 page; sync: focused agenda
High Power + Low Interest	Monthly or trigger-based	Crisp written update; rarely sync	< 250 words
Low Power + High Interest	Bi-weekly	Email digest; group thread	5 bullet points
Low Power + Low Interest	Quarterly or on-launch	Newsletter / launch email	Short

These are starting points. Adjust per stakeholder personality.

The engagement plan template

For each stakeholder, capture:

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### <Name / Role>

**Quadrant:** High-Power x Low-Interest (etc.)

**Cadence:** weekly / bi-weekly / monthly / quarterly / trigger-based

**Format:** crisp memo / email / sync / standup mention / newsletter

**Length:** < N words / < N min

**What they need from us (recurring):**
- ...

**What we need from them (recurring):**
- ...

**What they need from us right now (this period):**
- ...

**What we need from them right now (this period):**
- ...

**Channel of choice:** email / Slack / sync / Confluence
**Backup channel:** ...

**Stakeholder-specific notes:**
- (preferences, sensitivities, history with similar work)

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The "right now" rows are what change month-to-month; the "recurring" rows are stable.

Activity 1 — Engagement Style Calibration

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Practice picking the right engagement style on real-world examples, before applying it to the triad's stakeholders.

The engagement triage pack (8 stakeholder profiles)

Each card describes a stakeholder from a hypothetical company. The triad picks: cadence, format, length.

1. **CFO at a Series C company** — cares about cost forecasts, not implementation. Asks for ROI.
2. **Lead engineer on a partner team** — owns an API you depend on. Slack-first.
3. **Customer Success Manager for an at-risk top-10 account** — needs talking points; her customer is asking weekly.
4. **VP of Operations** — has 17 reports; her calendar is brutal; she vetoes things if she's surprised.
5. **A junior PM on an adjacent team** — high interest, low power, uses your work as a blueprint.
6. **A senior security architect** — every six weeks for compliance review; expects a written brief.
7. **A staff engineer in your own squad** — daily standup; weekly 1:1; needs detail.
8. **A regulator's outside counsel** — quarterly request for compliance evidence; expects formal documentation.

Triad protocol

1. **Place each on the Power x Interest grid** (10 min).
2. **Pick cadence + format + length** (15 min).
3. **Disagree productively** (10 min). For 1–2 cards your triad disagreed on, document why.

Readout (60 sec per triad)

"The trickiest one was [X] because [why]. We chose [Y] but the disagreement was [Z]."

Activity 2 — Build Your Recurring Engagement Plan

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

For each stakeholder on your map, fill in the **recurring** part of the engagement plan.

Triad protocol

1. **Sort stakeholders by quadrant** (5 min).
2. **For high-power x high-interest (typically 3–5)**: detailed plan (10 min). These are your closest partners.
3. **For high-power x low-interest (typically 3–5)**: crisp plan (10 min). The dangerous quadrant.
4. **For low-power x high-interest (typically 2–4)**: group plan (5 min). Email digests, group threads.
5. **For low-power x low-interest (typically 2–3)**: lightweight plan (5 min). Newsletter; launch comms.
6. **Sanity check** (5 min). Are you over-investing in any quadrant?

What "good" looks like

- **Most time** goes to high-power x high-interest stakeholders
- **Crispest writing** goes to high-power x low-interest stakeholders
- **Group channels** for low-power x high-interest (cohort engagement, not 1:1)

- **No invented meetings** — the plan respects calendar reality

Activity 3 — Build Your "Right Now" Asks

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

For each stakeholder, name what you need from them in the **next 2–4 weeks** and what they're likely to need from you.

The 3 most useful "asks" categories

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Decisions	Confirm scope; sign off on architecture stance; approve SLO targets
Information	Answer a specific question; share a doc; introduce someone
Action	Add a story to their team's backlog; schedule a review; make a call

For each stakeholder, list 1–3 asks per category that you'll need over the next month. Then identify the asks **they'll have for you**.

Triad protocol

1. **Walk each stakeholder** (20 min). For each, list 3–5 "right now" asks (mix of decisions, information, action).
2. **List reciprocal asks** (10 min). What will *they* ask of *you*? Predict the top 1–2 per stakeholder.
3. **Flag conflicts** (5 min). Are any of your asks in tension with each other? (e.g., asking the architect to defer a decision while asking the eng director to approve a launch date)
4. **Triage** (5 min). Which 5 asks across all stakeholders are the most consequential? Those go on the radar for Friday's negotiation.

What "good" looks like

- Each stakeholder has **specific** asks — "approve the SLO" beats "review the doc"
- Reciprocal asks are predicted, not surprises
- Conflicts are surfaced rather than buried
- The "5 most consequential" list is the input to Friday's negotiation simulations

Activity 4 — The "Engagement Anti-Patterns" Diagnostic

Format: Triad • 45 min + Wrap • Block 4

Purpose

Identify the engagement anti-patterns the triad is most prone to, and design counter-measures into the SEP §2.

The 6 most common engagement anti-patterns

ANTI-PATTERN	SYMPTOM	COUNTER-MEASURE
Channel sprawl	Same message via Slack DM + email + meeting	Commit to one channel of record per stakeholder
Rolling silence	Stakeholder hasn't been touched in 6 weeks; suddenly there's a problem	Calendar each cadence as a recurring meeting / reminder
Surprise reveal	Major decision shared after the fact	Engage early; pre-share before the public moment
Asymmetric asks	TPM only asks; never offers	Build "what we offer" into each engagement
Veto avoidance	TPM avoids the high-power-low-interest stakeholder	Trigger-based engagement from watch list
Email avalanche	TPM sends 20-page deck to a 250-word audience	Match length to audience

Triad protocol

1. **Score the triad's natural tendencies** (10 min). For each anti-pattern, rate yourselves H / M / L on susceptibility. Be honest.
2. **Design counter-measures** (15 min). For your top 2–3 anti-patterns, what's the specific counter-measure baked into your plan?
3. **Document in §2** (15 min).
4. **AI sanity check** (5 min). Run the prompt below.

AI prompt

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Role: Senior PM reviewing a junior TPM's engagement plan.
Context: <SEP §1 + §2 stakeholder list and engagement plans>
Task: Identify the top 3 engagement risks:
  1. A stakeholder likely under-served by the plan
  2. A stakeholder likely over-served (TPM is wasting attention)
  3. A specific anti-pattern the plan is exposed to
Constraints:
  - Be specific
  - Suggest a concrete adjustment
Format: 3 findings, each with: Risk / Why / Adjustment.
```

Wrap (last 15 min)

Each triad shares:

- The **engagement style** for one of their high-power x low-interest stakeholders
- The **most consequential ask** for the next month
- The **anti-pattern** they're most exposed to + the counter-measure

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad ends Day 2 with:

- ✓ Recurring engagement plan per stakeholder
- ✓ "Right now" asks per stakeholder (decisions / information / action)
- ✓ Reciprocal asks predicted
- ✓ **5 most consequential asks** identified
- ✓ Anti-pattern diagnostic + counter-measures
- ✓ AI provenance log entry
- ✓ SEP §2 drafted